

7-Column Dysfunctional Thought Record

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy · Client Worksheet + Clinician Guide

How to Use This Record

Instructions: Complete this record as close as possible to when you notice a strong emotion. Work through each column in order. The goal is not to think positively, but to think more accurately and completely. Even a small shift in mood ratings is a success.

Name:

Date:

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
SITUATION	MOODS	AUTOMATIC THOUGHTS	EVIDENCE SUPPORTING	EVIDENCE AGAINST	BALANCED PERSPECTIVE	RE-RATE MOODS
Who? What? Where? When?	Name each emotion. What went through your mind?	Facts that support the hot thought	Facts that contradict the hot thought	Write a balanced alternative that takes all evidence into account.	Re-rate each emotion from Column 2	
(Objective description only)	Rate 0-100%	Circle the HOT THOUGHT		(What would a judge say?)	Rate belief 0-100%	(0-100%)

Clinician Guide

The Dysfunctional Thought Record (DTR) is the core self-monitoring tool of CBT. Introduce it in session 2-3, after providing psychoeducation on the cognitive model. Complete the first record together in session before assigning as homework.

Identifying the Hot Thought

The hot thought is the automatic thought most closely connected to the emotional response — not necessarily the first thought. Ask: 'Which of these thoughts is making you feel the worst?'

Separating Thoughts from Feelings

Many clients initially write thoughts in Column 2 (Moods). Gently redirect: 'Feelings are usually one word — sad, anxious, ashamed. What were you feeling?' This distinction is fundamental.

Head-Heart Lag

When clients say 'I know it logically but still feel terrible,' normalize this. The intellectual shift precedes the emotional shift. Behavioral experiments build the experiential evidence needed for emotional change.

Frequency

Assign 1-2 records per week initially. More is not always better — quality over quantity. Review in session before the next assignment.